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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

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I particularly do not wish to give the impression that there is any one who disbelieves in witch-doctorhood. Most of my acquaintances believed that there are a few entirely reliable practitioners, but that the majority are quacks. Hence in the case of any particular witch-doctor they are never quite certain whether reliance can be placed on his statements or not. They know that some witch-doctors lie and that others tell the truth, but they cannot at once tell from his behaviour into which category any witch-doctor falls. They reserve judgement, and temper faith with scepticism.

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It is always possible to check the statements of a witch-doctor by putting them before the poison oracle, which, not being under human control, may contradict them, so that it is not surprising that Azande have developed doubts. I have heard even witch-doctors themselves admit that not all members of their corporation are reliable and honest, but only those who have received proper medicines from persons qualified to initiate them.

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My statements about scepticism are not based solely on remarks of individuals. Young nobles, and sometimes commoners of influence also, will test witch-doctors by playing a joke on them. An old prince would have too deep a sense of courtesy towards his subjects to put them to public shame in this manner. The following text describes the test:

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'If you want to know whether a witch-doctor cheats you cook some porridge and then pour some water into a pot as though it were a flavouring to accompany the porridge. You then carefully bind leaves round the top of the pot and place it by the side of the bowl of porridge. You say to the witch-doctor, "Tell us the name of the flavouring in that pot." If he does not tell you the name of the flavouring you give him nothing, but after you have let him dance a little you tell him that it is finished and that he may go. Nobles often play this trick. Some of them use a fowl's wing for the purpose. A noble takes the wing of a fowl, with which he [186](#) has previously consulted the poison oracle, and places it in front of him, and says to the witch-doctor, "Tell us the name of the man to whose name this fowl died." If the witch-doctor is himself a witch he gives the name of the man to whom the fowl died, because he knows it on account of his witchcraft. But he who is not a witch will in no wise give the man's name. Those witch-doctors who are themselves witches are few indeed. It is they also who do wonderful things. They beat their bellies and blood comes from their bellies out of their mouths. They summon bees and hornets and wasps to come and scatter every one. They open their mouths and millipedes and worms creep out. Those who do these things are witches in truth, there is no deception in their performances.'

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